UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 7 — Part A
Nature, Origin and Characteristics of Language

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Culture, language and communication: Nature, origin and characteristics of language ..." — with the language–culture–thought relationship the papers attach to it.

THE OPENING STORY

Around 650 BCE, says Herodotus, the Egyptian king Psammetichus wanted to know which language was oldest. He gave two newborns to a shepherd with orders that no one speak a word to them. Two years later the children ran to the shepherd crying "*bekos*!" — Phrygian for bread. The king concluded Phrygian was humanity's first tongue. **It was the first experiment on the origin of language, and it was wrong in every way that matters:** children do not grow a language out of silence, and no living language is "older" than another. In 1866 the Linguistic Society of Paris grew so tired of such guesses that it **banned papers on the origin of language**. This packet is about what we have learnt since.

What this topic is really about. Language is the one capacity every human group has and no other animal has in full. The topic asks three things: **what language is** (a system of arbitrary symbols, rule-governed and infinitely productive), **how it arose** (the old speculative theories, and the modern biological and cultural evidence), and **what makes it distinctive** (Hockett's design features). The papers then push one step further: **does the language you speak shape the way you think?** — the Sapir–Whorf question.

Study window	Opens 11 Nov 2026 — **half a day** (one session), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	2 hr first pass, including one written 15-mark answer
Revision time	15 min full note • 5 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Three units — **nature and design features**, **origin** (speculative → biological → cultural), and **language, culture and thought**. Learn Fig. 1 and Fig. 3 cold.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	Verbal and non-verbal communication, sociolinguistics, and language and inequality are **7-B**. Ethnoscience is **6-I**. Primate communication in biological detail is **1.4 / primate behaviour**; hominin anatomy is **1.8**.

Candid verdict — steady, and better than your tracker shows. Six stems from 1995 to 2026 fall in 7-A: **2010** (origin, biological and cultural, 30 marks), **2015** (emic/etic from the study of language, 10), **2018** (structure and content of language shaped by culture, 15), **2019** (linguistics and socio-cultural anthropology, 10), **2020** (Sapir–Whorf, 10) and **2025** (perspectives on culture, language and thought, 15) — plus a **1993** note on language and culture before your compilation's range. Your tracker has PYQ Count 5 and Mains Value **Low**; on six askings, including a 30-marker and a 15-marker as recently as 2025, I have set it to **High**. The language–culture–thought relation is the single most-asked strand: **four of the six**.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **The nature of language** — definitions (Sapir, Saussure, Chomsky), the sign, langue and parole, competence and performance, its levels.
- **Characteristics** — Hockett's design features, and the animal comparisons that test them: bees, vervets, signing apes.
- **Origin** — the speculative theories, the 1866 ban, the biological evidence (anatomy, brain, FOXP2, gesture, gossip), the cultural theories, and the timing debate.
- **Language, culture and thought** — Boas, Sapir–Whorf (strong and weak), the evidence for and against, neo-Whorfian work, and universalist replies.
- **Linguistics and anthropology** — the four-field tie, language as data, tool and model; emic/etic from phonemics.
- **Indian material** — linguistic diversity, kinship terms and honorifics, endangered languages.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
Kinesics, proxemics, paralanguage; ethnography of speaking; sociolinguistics; language and inequality	7-B	The social use of language — a different revision logic
Ethnoscience, componential analysis, colour terms	6-I, done	Named here as a perspective on culture and thought only
Lévi-Strauss's use of phonology	6-D, done	One line under "language as model"
Primate social behaviour; hominin fossils	Topic 1	Only the evidence that bears on language is used
Language as a basis of ethnicity and linguistic states	Paper II	Political use of language belongs there

How it connects outward

- **6-I** — cognitive anthropology took the "weak" Whorfian view and tested it on colour and plant terms. Berlin and Kay's universals are a reply to Whorf.
- **6-D** — Lévi-Strauss modelled kinship and myth on phonology; Pike's emic/etic came from the same source (2015 question).
- **7-B** — once language exists, its use in social context is the next question. The 2025 "perspectives" stem straddles both parts.
- **Topic 1** — the 2026 question on human evolution as a product of biological and cultural factors rewards the origin-of-language evidence.

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

1995–2021 wording and marks from your compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 7); 1993 from Edukemy; 2022–2026 checked against full papers. The 2019 and 2015 stems are filed under Unit 7 in your compilation.

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2025	Describe briefly the theoretical perspectives in linguistic anthropology to explain the relationship of culture, language and thought.	Boas → Sapir–Whorf → ethnoscience → neo-Whorfian	15
2020	Sapir–Whorf hypothesis (note).	Strong and weak, evidence, critique	10

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2019	The relationship between Linguistics and Social-cultural Anthropology.	Language as data, tool, model	10
2018	Critically examine that the structure and content of language are influenced by culture.	Culture → language, critically	15
2015	Explain the difference between 'Emic' & 'Etic' and how does the difference derive from the study of language?	Pike; phonemic/phonetic	10
2010	State the theories regarding the origin of spoken languages in human societies both from biological and cultural points of view.	Origin — two lenses	30
1993	Write a note on Language and culture.	Relationship (outside compilation range)	—

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper; GS Prelims has not tested this content. No Prelims facts are carried here.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
Language, culture and thought	4 — 1993, 2018, 2020, 2025	Which way the influence runs, with evidence on both sides	5.5 + Fig. 3. Master Answers 2 and 3
Origin	1 — 2010 (30 marks)	Speculative theories named, then biological and cultural evidence	5.4 + Fig. 2. Master Answer 1
Linguistics and anthropology	2 — 2015, 2019	Language as data, tool and model; emic/etic from phonemics	5.6. Master Answer 4
Nature and characteristics	0 directly	Never asked alone — but every answer opens with a definition and Hockett	5.1–5.3 + Fig. 1

Trend reading

- **Language and thought is the core.** Four of seven stems. Prepare Sapir–Whorf as a 10-mark note and as the spine of a 15-mark answer.
- **Origin is rare but heavy.** Asked once, for 30 marks. If it returns it will be 15 or 20 marks, and "biological and cultural" will again be the frame.
- **Recent gap, then a return.** Nothing in 2021–2024 or 2026; a 15-marker in 2025. Expect a short note or a relationship question.
- **Mains Value: High.** Six askings in the counted range, the most recent in 2025.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — Language is a symbol system. Arbitrary signs, combined by rules into an unlimited number of messages (Saussure, Sapir, Chomsky). Every human group has one; all are equally complex.

MOVE 2 — Its design features set it apart. Hockett (1960): of thirteen features, productivity, displacement, duality of patterning and cultural transmission are what bees, vervets and signing apes lack together. *Fig. 1*

MOVE 3 — It evolved, biologically and culturally. The speculative "bow-wow" theories gave way to evidence from anatomy, brain, genes, gesture and social life, and to cultural accounts of symbol, labour and cooperation. *Fig. 2*

MOVE 4 — It is bound up with culture and thought. Boas made language part of culture; Sapir and Whorf argued it shapes thought; the evidence supports a weak, not a strong, version. *Fig. 3*

MOVE 5 — It gave anthropology a method. Fieldwork in the native language, phonemics as a model for emic analysis, and structural linguistics as a model for Lévi-Strauss.

That chain is the shape of any answer: **symbol system → design features → evolution → culture and thought → method.**

What makes language human — Hockett's design features tested

filled = present · half-filled = partial or contested · open = absent — after Hockett 1960 and Hockett & Altmann 1968

Design feature	What it means	Honeybee waggle dance	Vervet alarm calls	Signing ape Washoe, Nim	Human
Arbitrariness	no natural link between sign and meaning ("dog" / "kutta")	●	●	●	●
Discreteness	built from separable units, not a smooth continuum	○	●	●	●
Semanticity	signals carry fixed meanings about the world	●	●	●	●
Displacement	talk about what is absent — yesterday, elsewhere, imagined	◐	○	◐	●
Productivity	make and understand messages never heard before	◐	○	◐	●
Duality of patterning	meaningless sounds combine into meaningful words	○	○	○	●
Cultural transmission	learnt from others, not inherited in fixed form	○	◐	◐	●
Prevarication	can lie, joke, pretend, speak of the impossible	○	◐	◐	●
Reflexiveness	language can talk about language itself	○	○	○	●

READ THE TABLE LIKE THIS

- The bee's dance points to nectar out of sight (some displacement, some productivity) — but only ever about food and nest sites.
- Vervets have three distinct alarm calls — "leopard", "eagle", "snake" — but cannot say "the leopard I saw yesterday".
- No animal system combines the four shaded features. That combination, not any single one, is what makes language human.

Fig. 1 — the hero diagram. Nine of Hockett's features against four communication systems. Ape and bee entries follow the standard textbook reading; half-filled circles mark claims that are contested (see 5.3). Draw the four shaded rows and the human column in an exam.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 What language is

STORY HOOK

A two-year-old who has never heard the sentence "the purple elephant ate my homework" understands it at once — and could invent ten more like it before lunch.

Why it helps: that is productivity, the feature that makes a finite set of words into infinite language.

Plain version. Language is a system of agreed-upon sounds (or signs) and rules for combining them, which lets people say and understand an endless number of new things.

- **Sapir (1921), *Language*:** "a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions and desires by means of a system of voluntarily produced symbols." MEMORISE
- **Anthropological working definition:** a culturally transmitted system of arbitrary symbols, organised by rules at several levels, through which members of a speech community communicate, think and transmit culture.
- **Saussure, *Course in General Linguistics* (1916):** the **sign** joins a **signifier** (sound-image) to a **signified** (concept), and the link is **arbitrary**. **Langue** is the shared system; **parole** is individual speech. Meaning comes from **difference** within the system.
- **Chomsky, *Syntactic Structures* (1957), *Aspects* (1965): competence** (the speaker's tacit knowledge of rules) versus **performance** (actual use); an innate **language acquisition device** and **universal grammar** explain why children learn so fast from so little — the "poverty of the stimulus".
- **Levels of structure:** phonology (sounds), morphology (word-building), syntax (sentence order), semantics (meaning), pragmatics (use in context).
- **No "primitive" languages.** Boas showed that the languages of small-scale societies are as complex as any; complexity is distributed differently, not lacking. This principle is the anthropological contribution to the definition.

5.2 The characteristics of language

Write these as a numbered list in any answer: **(1) symbolic and arbitrary; (2) rule-governed — grammar at every level; (3) productive and open; (4) displacement; (5) duality of patterning; (6) culturally transmitted, yet resting on a universal human capacity; (7) social — shared by a speech community; (8) dynamic — always changing; (9) universal — every society has a fully developed language; (10) reflexive — able to describe itself.** Each maps to a Hockett feature in Fig. 1.

> **The line that lifts a characteristics answer.** "No single feature is unique to human language; what is unique is the combination — arbitrary, discrete symbols, doubly patterned, endlessly productive, able to speak of the absent, and learnt rather than inherited."

5.3 Testing the features on animals

> **STORY HOOK**
> *In the early 1970s the chimpanzee Washoe saw a swan for the first time and signed **WATER BIRD**. Her trainers called it a new compound word. Herbert Terrace, after years with a chimp he named Nim Chimpsky, replied that the apes were mostly copying their teachers.*
> Why it helps: one image holds both sides of the ape-language debate.

- **Honeybee waggle dance** (Karl von Frisch; Nobel Prize 1973) — direction and distance to food out of sight. Displacement and some productivity, but only for one topic.
- **Vervet monkey alarm calls** (Seyfarth, Cheney & Marler 1980) — distinct calls for leopard, eagle and snake trigger different escapes. Semantic and discrete, but closed: no combination, no past tense.
- **Signing apes** — Washoe (Gardners, from 1966; Fouts); Koko (Patterson); Kanzi the bonobo with lexigrams (Savage-Rumbaugh). Vocabularies of hundreds of signs.
- **The critique** — Terrace, "Can an Ape Create a Sentence?" (*Science*, 1979): Nim's utterances did not grow in length or structure, and many repeated the teacher. No syntax, no questions asked for their own sake.
- **The verdict** — apes have rich symbolic capacity; they do not have productive, doubly patterned language. The gap is one of **degree in symbols, kind in syntax**.

5.4 The origin of language — the 2010 question

> **STORY HOOK**
> *A London family, known only as "KE", had three generations who struggled to sequence speech sounds. In 2001 geneticists traced it to a single-letter change in one gene — **FOXP2**. The press called it "the language gene". It isn't — but it was the first gene ever tied to speech.*
> Why it helps: FOXP2 is your anchor for the whole "biological" half, and the correction ("not the language gene") is your critical line.

(a) The speculative theories — name them, then dismiss them

Nickname	Claim	Associated with
Bow-wow	Words began as imitation of natural sounds (onomatopoeia)	Herder; mocked by Max Müller 1861
Pooh-pooh	Words began as instinctive cries of emotion	Interjectional theory
Ding-dong	A natural resonance between sound and object	Müller (later abandoned)
Yo-he-ho	Rhythmic chants of collective labour	Ludwig Noiré
La-la	Play, love, song and poetry	Otto Jespersen 1922
Ta-ta	Mouth movements imitating hand gestures	Richard Paget 1930

Why they failed: untestable, each explains a handful of words but not grammar, and all assume a "first word" rather than a system. The Société de Linguistique de Paris **banned the subject in 1866**. It returned in the 1990s on the strength of new evidence.

(b) Biological evidence

Line of evidence	Finding	Who, when
Vocal tract	The descended human larynx gives a large pharynx for varied vowels — at the cost of choking risk	Lieberman (1970s–)
Hyoid bone	A Neanderthal hyoid from Kebara cave, Israel, is almost modern in shape	Arensburg et al. 1989
Breathing control	The narrow thoracic spinal canal of the Nariokotome *H. erectus* boy suggests limited breath control; Neanderthals and moderns have it enlarged	MacLarnon & Hewitt 1999
Brain	Broca's and Wernicke's areas; endocasts of early *Homo* show a Broca's-area bulge	Broca 1861; Wernicke 1874; Tobias, Falk on *H. habilis*
Genes	FOXP2 mutation impairs speech sequencing; Neanderthals shared the human variant	Lai et al. 2001; Krause et al. 2007
Gesture first	Mirror neurons link action and perception; language began in the hands	Rizzolatti & Arbib 1998; Corballis, *From Hand to Mouth* 2002
Social bonding	Language replaced grooming as groups grew past ~150 — "gossip" as vocal grooming	Dunbar 1996
Protolanguage	Words without syntax came first; grammar later	Bickerton 1990
Saltation	A single mutation gave "Merge", the recursive operation behind syntax	Berwick & Chomsky, *Why Only Us* 2016

(c) Cultural evidence and theories

- **Labour and cooperation.** Engels, "The Part Played by Labour in the Transition from Ape to Man" (1876): men "had something to say to each other" in cooperative work. A materialist forerunner of today's cooperation theories.
- **Symbolic culture.** Beads, ochre and engravings (Blombos Cave, South Africa, c. 75,000 years ago) and the Upper Palaeolithic burst of art and ritual imply symbolic thought, and so language. Deacon, *The Symbolic Species* (1997): language and brain co-evolved through symbol use.
- **Language creates itself.** Deaf children brought together in Managua schools from the late 1970s built **Nicaraguan Sign Language** from scratch; each younger cohort made it more grammatical. Language needs a community, not only a brain.
- **Creoles.** Pidgins become full creoles in one generation of children — Bickerton's evidence that children supply grammar.
- **Monogenesis or polygenesis?** One ancestral language or several? Unresolvable from the evidence; say so.

(d) When?

Estimates run from about 2 million years (early *Homo*) to about 50,000 years (the Upper Palaeolithic). The common middle view: **a protolanguage with *H. erectus*, and fully modern, syntactic language with *H. sapiens* between roughly 200,000 and 100,000 years ago.** Write the range, not one date.

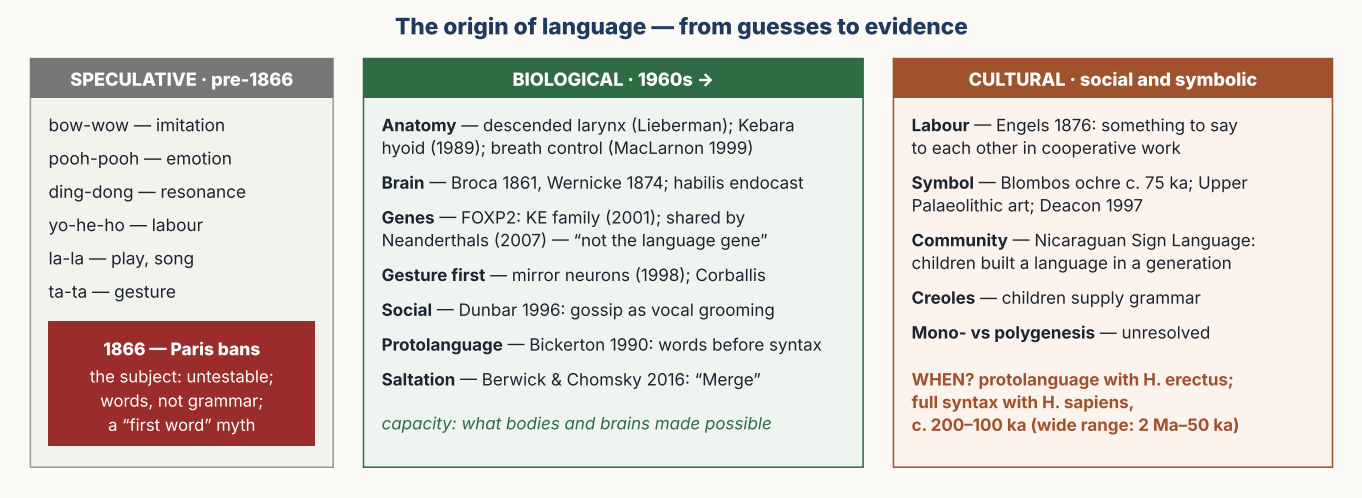


Fig. 2 — the 2010 answer on one page: why the speculative theories failed, then the biological evidence for capacity and the cultural evidence for use. Draw the three-column frame and fill two items per column.

5.5 Language, culture and thought — the core strand

STORY HOOK

*Before he was a linguist, Benjamin Lee Whorf was a fire-prevention inspector. He noticed that workers smoked freely around petrol drums labelled **"empty"** — empty of petrol, but full of explosive vapour. The word, he decided, had told them they were safe.*

Why it helps: it is the most memorable example of language shaping behaviour — and Whorf's own.

The positions

Position	Claim	Who
Language as part of culture; race, language and culture vary independently	Language is the best key to a culture, but does not determine it	Boas, *Handbook of American Indian Languages* 1911
Strong Whorf — linguistic determinism	Language determines thought; speakers of different languages live in different worlds	Whorf 1939–41 (as usually read)
Weak Whorf — linguistic relativity	Language influences habitual thought, attention and memory	Sapir 1929; most modern work
Culture shapes language	Vocabulary and grammar elaborate what a culture cares about	Boas; Evans-Pritchard on Nuer cattle terms
Language as culture's grammar	Culture is knowledge organised like language	Goodenough 1957; ethnoscience (6-I)
Universalism	Thought is largely independent of language; deep universals constrain all languages	Chomsky; Berlin & Kay 1969; Pinker 1994

Sapir (1929) — the classic statement: human beings do not live in the objective world alone but are very much at the mercy of the particular language that has become the medium of expression for their society. **Whorf (1940):** we dissect nature along lines laid down by our native languages. **MEMORISE** — paraphrase both closely; these are the two lines examiners expect.

The evidence — for and against

Case	What it shows	Verdict
Whorf's "empty drums"	A word's meaning guided careless behaviour	Anecdote
Hopi time — Whorf claimed Hopi had no words or tenses for time	Ekkehart Malotki, *Hopi Time* (1983), documented abundant Hopi time expressions	Refuted

Case	What it shows	Verdict
"Eskimo words for snow"	Boas mentioned a few roots (1911); retellings inflated them to dozens or hundreds	A myth — Martin 1986; Pullum 1991
Guugu Yimithirr, Australia	Speakers use north/south/east/west, not left/right — and keep track of compass direction at all times	Strong support (Haviland; Levinson 2003)
Colour terms	Universal foci and order (Berlin & Kay 1969), but category boundaries affect discrimination speed	Universal and relative
Grammatical gender, number	Small effects on attention and description in experiments	Weak relativity
Culture → language	Nuer cattle-colour vocabulary; Dravidian kin terms marking cross-cousins as marriageable	Vocabulary follows interest

The balanced verdict. The strong version is untenable — people translate, borrow, learn new languages and think without words. The weak version is supported: language **channels habitual attention** (direction, colour, number) without imprisoning thought. Influence runs **both ways**: culture elaborates vocabulary, and the categories a language makes easy become the categories people habitually use.

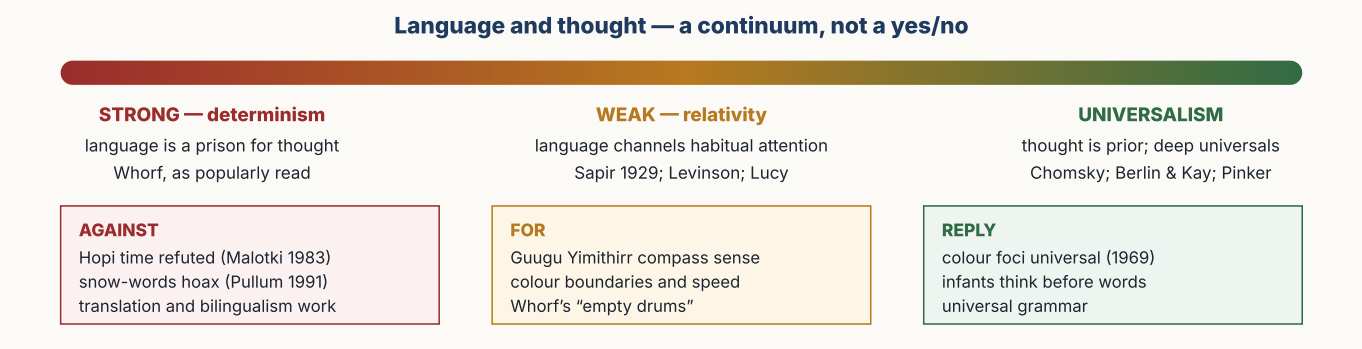


Fig. 3 — place every position on one line. The examiner rewards an answer that ends in the middle: the weak version, with evidence on both sides.

5.6 Linguistics and anthropology — the 2015 and 2019 questions

STORY HOOK

An English speaker hears the "p" in pin (with a puff of air) and in spin (without) as the same sound. A Hindi speaker hears two different sounds — ph and p — because in Hindi that difference changes words (phal "fruit", pal "moment").

Why it helps: that is phonetic versus phonemic — and Pike's etic versus emic — in one breath.

- **Language as subject.** Linguistic anthropology is one of Boas's four fields; Sapir, Whorf, Hymes and Gumperz built it.
- **Language as tool.** Fieldwork in the native language — Malinowski's rule in *Argonauts* (1922); texts, myths and genealogies are collected in language.
- **Language as data.** Kin terms, colour terms and plant names reveal social structure and classification (Morgan 1871; Conklin; 6-I).
- **Language as model.** Phonology gave Lévi-Strauss his structural method; Pike's emic/etic came from phonemic/phonetic (1954); Geertz's "culture as text" is another linguistic metaphor.
- **Language as history.** Historical linguistics reconstructs migrations and contact — the Indo-European family, Dravidian and Munda in India; Swadesh's glottochronology (1950s) dated splits by rates of word loss.
- **Emic and etic (2015). Phonetics** describes all the sounds speakers make with a universal grid; **phonemics** picks out the contrasts that change meaning in one language. Pike (1954) generalised this: an **etic** account uses the observer's cross-cultural categories; an **emic** account uses the distinctions meaningful to the people. Harris used the pair for his cultural materialism (6-G).

5.7 India — where to use it

STORY HOOK

In January 2010, Boa Sr died in Port Blair aged about 85. She was the last speaker of Bo, one of the Great Andamanese languages — for years she had no one left to talk to in her mother tongue, and spoke to birds instead.

Why it helps: a single human life makes language endangerment concrete — and it is Indian.

- **Diversity.** Four major families — Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Austroasiatic (Munda), Tibeto-Burman — plus Andamanese. Census 2011 recorded 19,569 raw mother-tongue returns, rationalised to 121 languages; 22 are in the Eighth Schedule. Ganesh Devy's People's Linguistic Survey of India counted about 780 languages.
- **Culture shapes vocabulary.** Dravidian terms separate cross-cousins (potential spouses, e.g. *maradalu* in Telugu) from parallel cousins (classed with siblings) — a kin terminology that encodes the marriage rule.
- **Language encodes hierarchy.** Hindi *aap / tum / tu*, Telugu *meeru / nuvvu*: pronouns of respect mark age, status and caste. Developed in 7-B.
- **Endangerment.** Great Andamanese languages; many tribal languages without a script or schooling. Mother-tongue instruction in early grades, where possible, under NEP 2020.

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	Sapir's 1921 definition • Saussure: signifier/signified, arbitrary, langue/parole (1916) • Chomsky: competence/performance, LAD • Hockett 1960 and the four key features • the six speculative nicknames and the 1866 ban • FOXP2: KE family 2001, Neanderthals 2007 • Sapir 1929 and Whorf 1940 lines (close paraphrase) • Pike 1954 emic/etic from phonemic/phonetic
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	Why the combination of features matters • the ape-language debate • the biological/cultural frame for origin • strong vs weak Whorf with evidence both ways • influence running both directions • four roles of language in anthropology
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Kebara hyoid and thoracic canal details • Bickerton, Deacon, Berwick & Chomsky • Blombos • glottochronology • Census and PLSI numbers

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Herodotus, Psammetichus	"Bekos" — the first origin experiment	An opening line for 2010	Babies and bread
Paris, 1866	Société de Linguistique bans origin papers	Why speculation failed	The ban
Sapir, 1921	"purely human and non-instinctive …"	The definition	—
Saussure, 1916	Sign; arbitrariness; langue/parole	Nature of language	—
Hockett, 1960	Design features; productivity, displacement, duality, cultural transmission	Characteristics	Purple elephant
Seyfarth, Cheney & Marler, 1980	Vervet alarm calls	Animal comparison	Leopard, eagle, snake
Terrace, 1979	Nim Chimpsky; no syntax	Ape critique	Water bird
Lai et al., 2001	FOXP2, KE family	Biological origin	KE family
Dunbar, 1996	Gossip as grooming	Social origin	—
Nicaraguan Sign Language	Children create a language, late 1970s on	Cultural origin	Managua schools

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Whorf, 1939–41	"Empty" drums; Hopi; determinism	Sapir–Whorf	Fire inspector
Malotki, 1983	*Hopi Time* refutes Whorf	Critique	—
Pullum, 1991	Great Eskimo Vocabulary Hoax	Critique	Snow words
Levinson, 2003	Guugu Yimithirr absolute direction	Neo-Whorfian support	"Ant on your north leg"
Pike, 1954	Emic/etic	2015 question	*phal* / *pal*
Boa Sr, 2010	Last speaker of Bo	Endangerment; India	Talking to birds

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Sign	A sound-image joined to a concept	Nature	"For Saussure the sign is arbitrary: nothing about 'tree' resembles a tree."
Langue / parole	The shared system / individual speech	Nature	"Anthropologists record parole to reconstruct langue."
Competence / performance	Tacit knowledge of rules / actual use	Chomsky; 7-B contrast	"Hymes added communicative competence to Chomsky's grammatical one."
Phoneme	The smallest sound unit that changes meaning	Emic/etic	"/p/ and /ph/ are separate phonemes in Hindi."
Morpheme	The smallest unit of meaning	Duality	"Un-kind-ness has three morphemes."
Displacement	Talking about what is absent	Characteristics	"Displacement lets myths speak of ancestors."
Productivity	Making new messages without limit	Characteristics	"Productivity is what apes most clearly lack."
Duality of patterning	Meaningless sounds → meaningful words	Characteristics	"Duality lets forty phonemes yield a hundred thousand words."
Protolanguage	Words without grammar	Origin	"Bickerton placed a protolanguage with *H. erectus*."
Linguistic relativity	Language influences habitual thought	Sapir–Whorf	"The weak version, linguistic relativity, survives."
Linguistic determinism	Language fixes thought	Sapir–Whorf	"Strong determinism fails on translation."
Speech community	People sharing a language and its norms of use	Nature; 7-B	"A speech community shares rules of use, not only of grammar."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Language (Sapir 1921):** a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions and desires by means of a system of voluntarily produced symbols.
- **Sapir–Whorf hypothesis:** the proposition that the structure of a language influences (weak form) or determines (strong form) the way its speakers perceive and think about the world.
- **Emic and etic (Pike 1954):** emic categories are those meaningful within a system to its members, as phonemes are; etic categories are the observer's cross-cultural grid, as phonetics is.

Exam-ready opening hooks

- (Origin) "Herodotus records that Pharaoh Psammetichus raised two infants in silence to discover the first language; their 'bekos' convinced him it was Phrygian. Modern anthropology asks the same question with better evidence."
- (Sapir–Whorf) "Whorf the fire inspector saw workers smoke beside 'empty' petrol drums full of vapour — a word, he concluded, had shaped their behaviour."
- (Characteristics) "A bee can direct her sisters to nectar out of sight, but cannot tell them about yesterday, or lie."

Analytical and transition lines

- "No single design feature is unique; the combination is."
- "Biology explains the capacity for language; culture explains why it is used and how it varies."
- "The influence runs both ways: culture elaborates vocabulary, and language channels habitual attention."

Criticism and qualification lines

- "FOXP2 is a gene for speech motor control, not 'the language gene'."
- "Malotki's *Hopi Time* dismantled the strongest example of linguistic determinism."
- "The famous 'Eskimo snow words' are a myth of retelling, not a finding of fieldwork."

Conclusions

- "Language is at once a biological capacity, a cultural system and a social practice; anthropology alone studies all three."
- "The weak Whorfian view — language as a lens, not a cage — is where the evidence rests."

India linkages

- Four families plus Andamanese • Census 2011: 121 languages, 22 scheduled • PLSI ~780 • Dravidian cross-cousin terms • *aap/tum/tu* • Boa Sr and Bo (2010) • NEP 2020 mother-tongue instruction.

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — design features	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	Nature; characteristics; animal comparison	Four shaded rows (displacement, productivity, duality, cultural transmission) × bee / vervet / ape / human, with filled, half and open circles
Fig. 2 — origin	Draw for origin	2010-type question	Three columns: speculative (with 1866), biological, cultural; "when?" at the foot
Fig. 3 — the continuum	Draw for Sapir–Whorf	2018, 2020, 2025	One line, strong → weak → universalism, with one case under each

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Human language against animal communication

Fig. 1 is the comparison. In words: animal systems are **closed** (a fixed set of signals), **stimulus-bound** (no displacement or lying), **largely innate** and **single-level**; human language is **open, displaced, learnt and doubly patterned**.

11.2 Saussure against Chomsky

Basis	Saussure	Chomsky
Key pair	Langue / parole	Competence / performance

Basis	Saussure	Chomsky
Where language lives	In the social system	In the individual mind
Focus	The sign; meaning by difference	Syntax; generative rules
Origin view	Not addressed	Innate universal grammar
Anthropological use	Lévi-Strauss; structuralism	Universals; criticised by Hymes (7-B)

11.3 Biological against cultural accounts of origin

Basis	Biological	Cultural
Explains	The capacity	The use and its variety
Evidence	Fossils, anatomy, genes, brain	Archaeology of symbol; living cases of language creation
Typical claim	Language needs a body and brain built for it	Language needs a community that uses it
Joint view	Gene–culture co-evolution: symbol use shaped brains that made more symbol use possible (Deacon)	

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (20 marks — the 2010 stem, asked for 30). "State the theories regarding the origin of spoken languages in human societies both from biological and cultural points of view."

Herodotus tells of Pharaoh Psammetichus raising two infants in silence to find the first language. Speculation of this kind was so fruitless that the Linguistic Society of Paris banned the subject in 1866. It returned, a century later, on biological and cultural evidence.

Speculative theories. Language was said to begin in imitation of natural sounds (bow-wow), cries of feeling (pooh-pooh), a natural resonance between sound and thing (ding-dong), the chants of collective labour (yo-he-ho, Noiré), play and song (la-la, Jespersen) or mouth gestures copying the hands (ta-ta, Paget). Each explains a few words, none explains grammar, and none can be tested.

Biological view. Speech needs a body and brain. The descended larynx enlarges the vocal tract (Lieberman); a nearly modern Neanderthal hyoid from Kebara (1989) and an enlarged thoracic canal for breath control (MacLarnon and Hewitt 1999) suggest speech by the Neanderthal–modern ancestor. Broca's and Wernicke's areas are language centres, and an endocast of *H. habilis* shows a Broca's bulge. The FOXP2 mutation in the KE family (2001) impairs speech sequencing, and Neanderthals shared the human variant (2007). Gesture-first theories draw on mirror neurons (Rizzolatti and Arbib 1998; Corballis 2002); Dunbar (1996) sees language as vocal grooming for large groups; Bickerton (1990) proposes a syntax-free protolanguage.

Cultural view. Engels (1876) tied speech to cooperative labour. The ochre and beads of Blombos (c. 75,000 years) and the Upper Palaeolithic burst of art imply symbolic thought. Deacon (1997) argues that symbol use and the brain co-evolved. Living cases show that language needs a community: deaf children in Managua created Nicaraguan Sign Language within a generation, and children turn pidgins into creoles.

[Draw Fig. 2.]

Assessment. Dates range from 2 million to 50,000 years ago; a common view places a protolanguage with *H. erectus* and full syntax with *H. sapiens*, perhaps 200,000–100,000 years ago. FOXP2 is not a "language gene", and the fossil evidence for speech is indirect. Biology explains the **capacity**, culture the **use**; the two co-evolved.

About 380 words — right for 20 marks; for 30, add the timing debate as a paragraph and the vervet/ape comparison. The opening story is your hook.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (10 marks, about 150 words). "Sapir–Whorf hypothesis." (2020)

The Sapir–Whorf hypothesis holds that the structure of a language shapes how its speakers perceive and think. Sapir (1929) wrote that people are at the mercy of the language of their society; Whorf, a fire inspector, saw workers smoke beside "empty" petrol drums full of vapour, and argued from Hopi that its speakers conceived time unlike Europeans.

A **strong** version (determinism) says language fixes thought; a **weak** version (relativity) says it influences habitual attention. The strong version fails: Malotki's *Hopi Time* (1983) found abundant Hopi time terms, the "Eskimo snow words" are a myth (Pullum 1991), and translation works. The weak version has support: Guugu Yimithirr speakers, who use compass terms instead of left and right, track direction constantly (Levinson 2003).

The evidence points to language as a lens, not a cage — and to culture shaping language as much as the reverse.

About 160 words.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (15 marks). "Critically examine that the structure and content of language are influenced by culture." (2018) — also serves 2025.

Language is part of culture, its main vehicle of transmission, and, as Boas showed, the best guide to how a people classify their world. The question is how far culture shapes language — and how far the influence runs the other way.

Content. Vocabulary elaborates what a culture cares about: Nuer cattle-colour terms (Evans-Pritchard), Hanunóo plant names (Conklin), Dravidian terms that mark cross-cousins as potential spouses — a kin terminology that encodes the marriage rule. Borrowing follows contact: English "pyjama", "bungalow", Hindi "school", "ticket".

Structure. Grammar too carries culture. Honorific pronouns — Hindi *aap/tum/tu*, Telugu *meeru/nuvvu*, Javanese speech levels — build social hierarchy into grammar. Evidential markers in some languages oblige speakers to say how they know. Guugu Yimithirr's absolute directions fit a way of life lived in landscape.

The reverse influence. Sapir and Whorf argued that language shapes thought. In its weak form this has support (Levinson's spatial studies); in its strong form it fails (Malotki on Hopi time).

Critique. Much of grammar is not cultural: Chomsky's universal grammar and Berlin and Kay's colour universals (1969) show deep constraints on all languages; Boas himself held that race, language and culture vary independently. Popular examples such as the "Eskimo snow words" are exaggerated. Culture works most clearly on **vocabulary and pragmatics**, least on **core syntax**.

[Draw Fig. 3.] The relation is reciprocal: culture elaborates language, and language channels habitual thought — within limits set by universal human capacities.

About 300 words. The structure/content split is in the question — use it as your headings.

MASTER ANSWER 4 (10 marks) — skeleton. "Explain the difference between emic and etic, and how it derives from the study of language." (2015)

- **Open:** Pike 1954, *Language in Relation to a Unified Theory of the Structure of Human Behavior*.
- **Linguistic root:** phonetics = all sounds on a universal grid; phonemics = contrasts that change meaning in one language. Hindi *phal/pal* vs English *pin/spin*.
- **Generalised:** emic = insider's meaningful distinctions; etic = observer's comparative categories.
- **Use:** cognitive anthropology (emic, 6-I); Harris's cultural materialism (etic priority, 6-G).
- **Close:** both are needed — emic for meaning, etic for comparison.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Sapir–Whorf hypothesis.	10	H R S
2	Characteristics of human language.	10	R D
3	Emic and etic and their linguistic origin.	10	H S
4	Relationship between linguistics and socio-cultural anthropology.	10	H S
5	Language and culture.	10	H S I
6	How does human language differ from animal communication? Illustrate with examples.	15	R D S
7	Critically examine that the structure and content of language are influenced by culture.	15	H R S I
8	Describe the theoretical perspectives in linguistic anthropology on culture, language and thought.	15	H R D S
9	Discuss the biological and cultural theories of the origin of language.	20	H R D S
10	"Language is a biological capacity and a cultural product." Discuss.	15	S
11	Discuss language endangerment in India and its anthropological significance.	15	I
12	Evaluate the evidence for language among Neanderthals.	15	S

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)

- Sapir's definition, word for word.
- Saussure's sign and langue/parole; Chomsky's competence/performance.
- Hockett's four key features, with one animal that lacks each.
- Strong and weak Sapir–Whorf in one sentence each.
- Emic/etic from phonemic/phonetic, with the Hindi example.

Factual anchors (5)

- Six speculative theories with one name each; the 1866 ban.
- FOXP2 — family, year, Neanderthal finding.
- Three anatomical lines of evidence with dates.
- Two refutations of strong Whorf, with authors.
- Two Indian facts on linguistic diversity.

Comparisons (3)

- Human vs animal communication on four features.
- Saussure vs Chomsky on four bases.
- Biological vs cultural origin accounts.

Critical judgement (2)

- Why is FOXP2 not "the language gene"?
- Where does the language–thought evidence finally rest?

Diagram reproduction (2)

- Draw Fig. 1's four shaded rows across four systems.
- Draw Fig. 3's continuum with one case under each pole.

Story recall (1)

- Tell each hook in one line: bekos, water bird, KE family, empty drums, *phal/pal*, Boa Sr.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

Symbol system — arbitrary signs, rule-governed, productive (Sapir 1921; Saussure 1916; Chomsky 1957/65) → **design features** — productivity, displacement, duality, cultural transmission together are uniquely human (Hockett 1960) → **origin** — speculative theories banned 1866; biological capacity (larynx, hyoid, Broca, FOXP2, gesture, gossip) and cultural use (labour, symbol, community) → **culture and thought** — Boas; Sapir–Whorf strong fails, weak survives; influence both ways → **method** — language as tool, data, model (emic/etic).

ESSENTIAL TERMS

sign • signifier/signified • langue/parole • competence/performance • phoneme/morpheme • arbitrariness • displacement • productivity • duality of patterning • cultural transmission • protolanguage • linguistic relativity/determinism • emic/etic • speech community

STORY HOOKS

Psammetichus' *bekos* • Paris ban 1866 • purple elephant (productivity) • bee, vervet, Washoe's WATER BIRD, Nim • KE family/FOXP2 • Managua deaf children • Whorf's "empty" drums • Hopi time • snow-word hoax • Guugu Yimithirr • *phal/pal* • Boa Sr 2010

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Saussure 1916 • Sapir 1921/1929 • Whorf 1939–41 • Boas 1911 • Pike 1954 • Chomsky 1957/65 • Hockett 1960/68 • Terrace 1979 • Seyfarth et al. 1980 • Malotki 1983 • Bickerton 1990 • Pullum 1991 • Dunbar 1996 • Deacon 1997 • Lai et al. 2001 • Levinson 2003 • Krause et al. 2007

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. Language is a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions and desires by means of a system of voluntarily produced symbols. (Sapir)
- 2. No single design feature is unique to human language; the combination is.
- 3. Biology explains the capacity for language; culture explains its use — and the two co-evolved.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 four shaded features × bee/vervet/ape/human • Fig. 2 speculative | biological | cultural, with "when?" • Fig. 3 strong ← weak → universalism.

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- FOXP2 is **not** "the language gene".
- The strong Whorf view is the one that fails; do not attack the weak one with the same evidence.
- "Eskimo snow words" is a myth — cite it only as a myth.
- Emic/etic is Pike's (1954), from phonemic/phonetic — not Harris's.
- No language is "primitive" — Boas.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

What this note was built from

- **UPSC syllabus** — Paper I, clause 7 (first part).
- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 7); Edukemy 2013–2023 list (adds 1993); 2024 and 2026 papers (no Unit 7 stem); 2025 Q6(c).
- **Standard sources** — Saussure (1916); Sapir (1921, 1929); Whorf (1956 collection); Boas (1911); Pike (1954); Chomsky (1957, 1965); Hockett (1960) and Hockett & Altmann (1968); Terrace (1979); Seyfarth, Cheney & Marler (1980); Malotki (1983); Pullum (1991); Levinson (2003); Lai et al. (2001); Krause et al. (2007); Dunbar (1996); Deacon (1997); Bickerton (1990).

Where you should be careful

- **The 2019 and 2015 stems** are filed under Unit 7 in your compilation; I count them in 7-A. The 2021 "branches of linguistic anthropology" stem I count in 7-B.
- **Mains Value.** Your tracker had PYQ Count 5 and Low; I count six and set it High. If you count 1993 it is seven.
- **Hooks and estimates.** Herodotus is a story, not evidence; ape-language claims are disputed (hence the half-filled circles); origin dates have a wide range; Census and PLSI counts use different methods. Sapir and Whorf lines are close paraphrase — paraphrase them in the exam too.